



Phishing Awareness

Strengthening the Human Firewall Against Social Engineering

The Digital Bait

Understanding what phishing is and why it remains the #1 threat vector in cybersecurity.

Defining Phishing

What is Phishing?

A type of social engineering where attackers trick users into revealing sensitive information—such as passwords or financial data—by impersonating a trusted entity via digital communication.

Why It Works

Unlike technical exploits, phishing targets the "human element." It exploits trust, curiosity, and urgency, making it far easier and cheaper for hackers than breaking through firewalls.

Psychological Triggers



Urgency

"Act now or your account will be suspended!" Panic clouds judgment and leads to mistakes.



Authority

Impersonating a CEO, HR, or a government agency to bypass standard verification protocols.



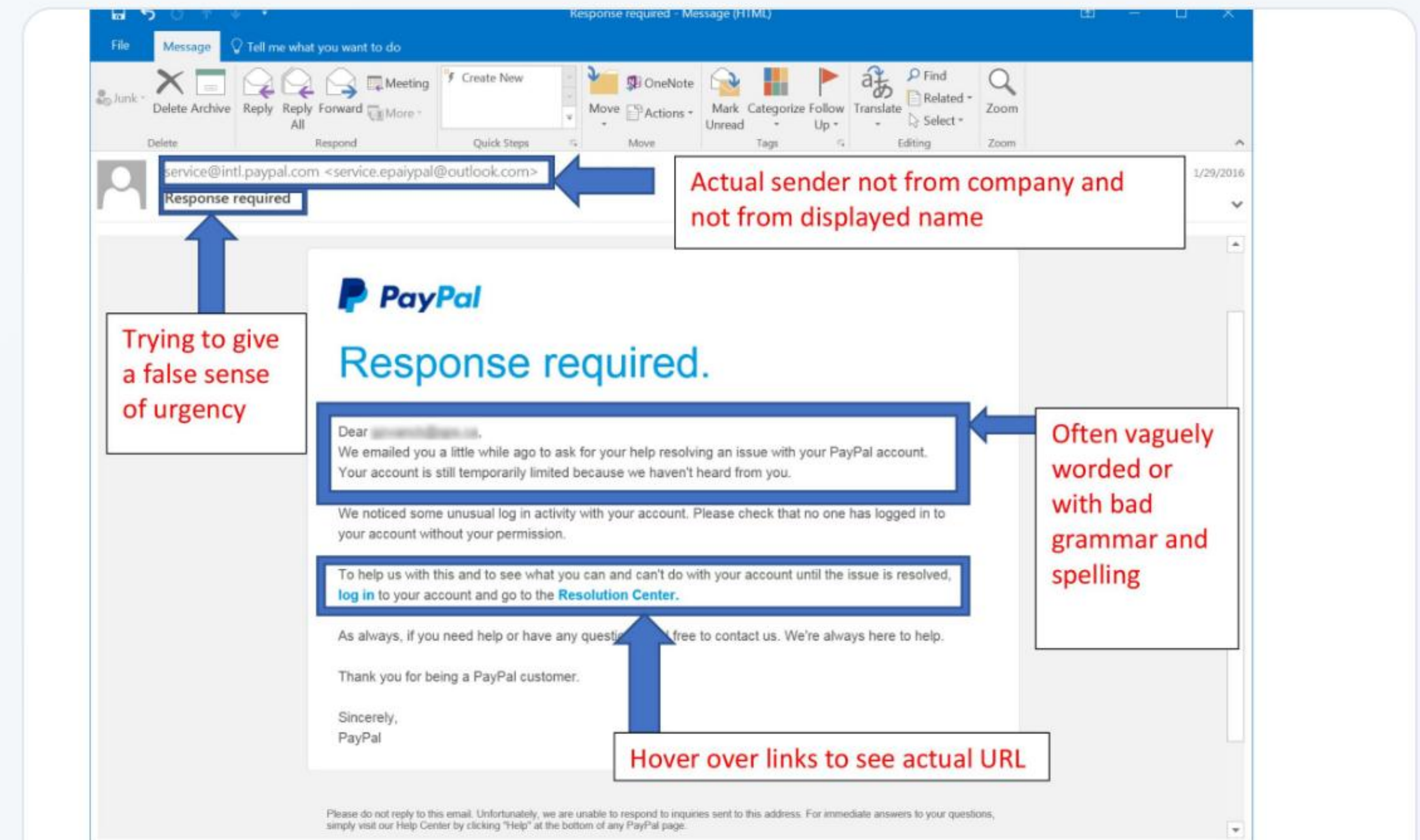
Fear

Using threats of negative consequences to compel a user to open a malicious attachment or link.

Anatomy of a Phishing Email

Look for the subtle signs:

- **Suspicious Sender:** The name looks right, but the email address is mismatched (e.g., support@microsoft.com).
- **Generic Greetings:** Using "Dear Customer" instead of your actual name.
- **Hidden Links:** Hovering reveals a strange URL that doesn't match the company domain.



Even if you think the email is legitimate, if it is not something you are expecting it is a good idea to contact the person you believe to be the sender "out-of-band," or by another method than clicking "reply" or any links in the email. For example, call a phone number you know belongs to the institution or person or go directly to their website by typing in the URL.

Common Red Flags



Spelling & Grammar Errors

Professional companies have editors; phishing emails often contain awkward phrasing or typos.



Unexpected Attachments

Be wary of unsolicited invoices, tax forms, or shipping receipts, especially in .zip or .html formats.



Shortened URLs

Attackers use Bitly or TinyURL to hide the final destination of a malicious link.



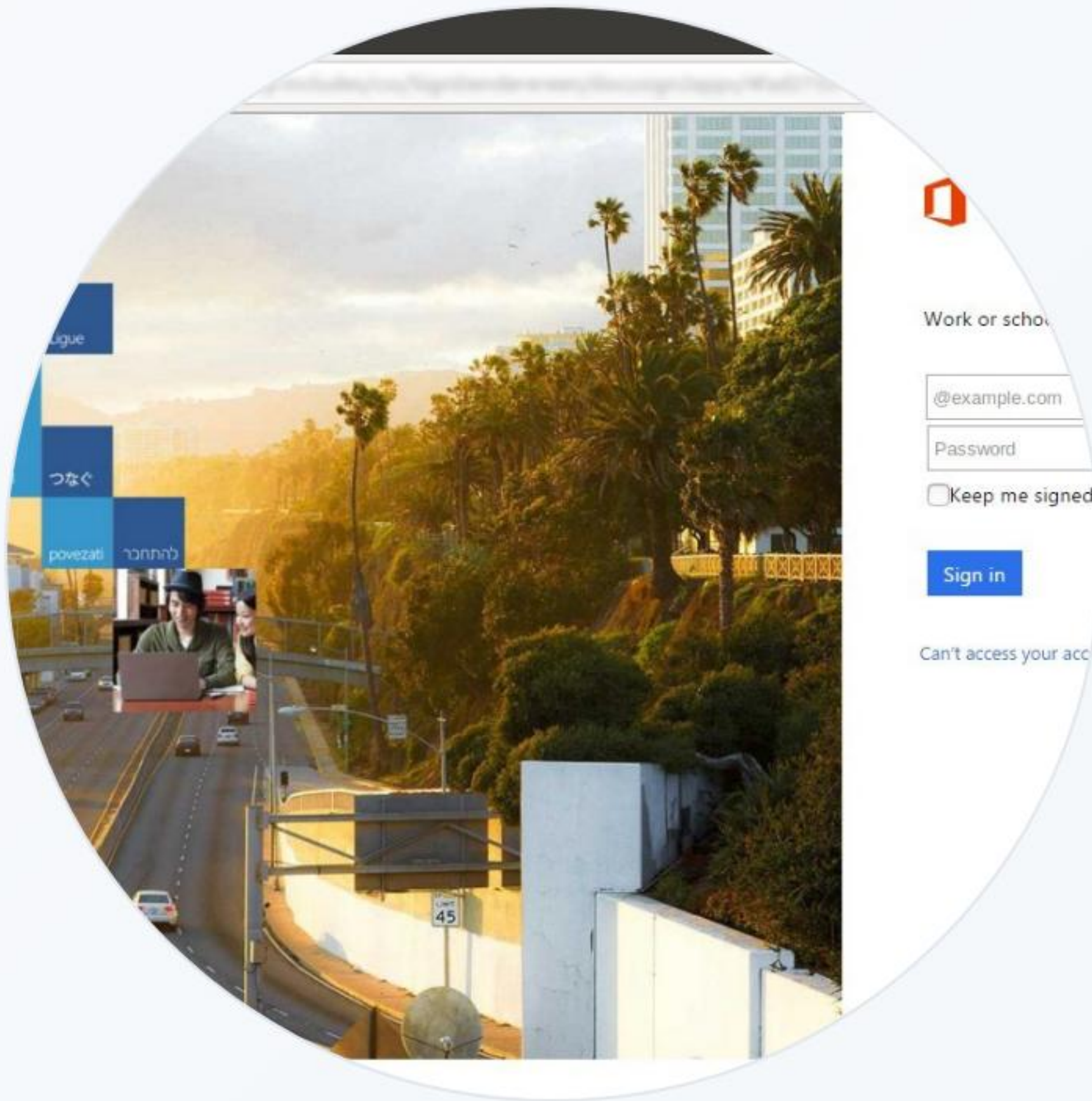
Unusual Requests

Be cautious if an executive asks for a "confidential" wire transfer or gift cards.

Brands Most Impersonated (2024)

Brand	Tactics Used	Primary Goal
Microsoft	Password Reset / Security Alerts	Credential Harvesting
LinkedIn	Profile Views / Message Alerts	Workplace Data Theft
DHL / FedEx	Package Delivery Updates	Malware / Tracking Phishing
PayPal	Unauthorized Transaction Alerts	Financial Account Access

Spotting Fake Websites



The Visual Deception

Scammers create pixel-perfect replicas of login pages for Microsoft 365, Google, and banks. These sites look 100% legitimate until you look at the address bar. Always check for HTTPS and a correctly spelled domain name before entering credentials.

The Cost of a Single Click

\$4.88M

Avg. Cost of a Phishing Breach

A Massive Impact

According to the 2025 IBM Report, phishing is the most expensive and common entry point for data breaches. This includes recovery costs, legal fees, and reputational damage that can last years.

Defense Strategies

Beyond the Inbox

1. **Hover Before You Click:** Always preview links to see their true destination.
2. **Enable Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA):** A stolen password is useless if you have an extra layer of protection on your phone.
3. **Report It:** Use your organization's "Report Phish" button. It helps security teams protect the entire company.

MULTI-FACTOR AUTHENTICATION



Quick Quiz

"You receive an urgent email from your 'Bank' asking to verify a large purchase. The email address is service@bank-security-alert.net. What do you do?"

A) Click the link to secure your account.

B) Close the email and call your bank's official number.

Correct Answer: B



Stay Vigilant

Cybersecurity is a shared responsibility. When in doubt, throw it out!

Task 2: Phishing Awareness Training | CodeAlpha Internship



Image Sources



<https://www.bitlyft.com/hs-fs/hubfs/Anatomy-of-a-Phishing-Email.jpg?width=2422&height=2116&name=Anatomy-of-a-Phishing-Email.jpg>

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